



▲ **LARGEST LIVING STRUCTURE**
The Great Barrier Reef extends along Australia's Pacific coast, from the Tropic of Capricorn near Brisbane to the Torres Strait between Australia and New Guinea.

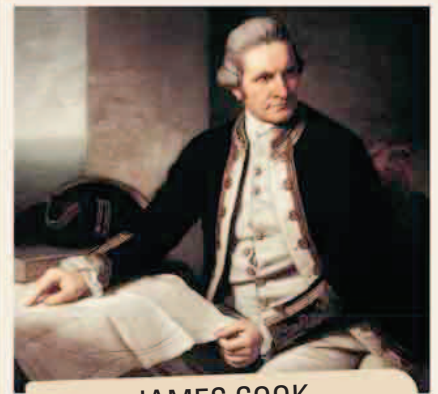


BIG BUILD-UP

The organisms that created the reef consist of about 400 different types of hard corals. They have been depositing the limestone that builds up the reef for 15 million years. But the reef's development has been interrupted many times, and the current phase of growth has lasted for 6,000 years.

FANTASTIC DIVERSITY

The Great Barrier Reef supports an amazing diversity of life, with more than 1,500 species of fish, 30 species of whales and dolphins, and at least 5,000 species of mollusks. Each has its own way of surviving on the reef, and they interact in a web of life that is one of the richest and most complex on the planet.



JAMES COOK

People have been fishing on the Great Barrier Reef for more than 40,000 years, but it was unknown to science until 1770. In that year, British explorer Captain James Cook and his crew were sailing up the coast of Australia in their ship *Endeavour* when they discovered the reef by crashing into it. The ship nearly sank, and had to be repaired on the beach at what is now Cooktown, north of Cairns.

